A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies

Bartolomé de las Casas · 1552

Source: Bartolomé de las Casas, Brevísima relación de la destrucción de las Indias (1552), English translation

A Spanish Dominican friar who had been an early colonist, las Casas came to condemn the brutal treatment of Native peoples under the encomienda system. Writing to the Spanish Crown, he catalogued atrocities to argue for reform. His account fueled the "Black Legend" of Spanish cruelty and remains a powerful — if one-sided — window into the human cost of conquest and the Columbian Exchange.

Connect: How does las Casas's purpose — persuading the Crown to reform — shape what he chose to describe and how he described it?

Key Passages

On the peoples of the Indies

"God has created all these numberless people to be the simplest, without malice or duplicity … most humble, most patient, most peaceable and calm, without strife nor tumults."

On the conduct of the conquerors

"Into this sheepfold … there came the Spaniards, who … immediately behaved like ravening beasts … Their reason for killing and destroying … is that the Christians have an ultimate aim, which is to acquire gold, and to swell themselves with riches in a very brief time."

On the scale of loss

"We are able to affirm … that in the forty years that have passed … there have been unjustly slain more than twelve million souls, women and children among the number."

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Spanish conquest of the Caribbean and Mexico and the encomienda system forced Native peoples into labor; war, abuse, and disease caused their populations to collapse.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The Spanish Crown (Prince Philip, later Philip II) and royal officials who could reform colonial policy; the printed book soon reached readers across Europe.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	A Dominican friar and former encomienda holder turned reformer; writing to win reform, he stresses Spanish cruelty, and Native voices appear only through his account.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE effect of the encomienda system on Native populations.

2. How might las Casas's role as a friar have shaped both his message and his intended audience?

3. Why should historians read this source critically even though it defends Native peoples?